



THE OPPOSITION: (above) Digvijay with Nath, (right) Bharati

idea is to promote social audit so that it obviates the need for the chief minister to visit rural areas," says Chauhan. In Khandwa district in July, he suspended two officials of the Tribal Welfare Department, one of them an assistant commissioner, on charges of graft.

Having advocated the involvement of stakeholders in policy formulation since his early days as a Lok Sabha MP, he has been holding caste and sector-based panchayats at his residence. And Chauhan doesn't mind when delegates get worked up and make their points animatedly. During the Laghu Udyog Panchayat in June, small industry owners were vehement in running down the state's bureaucracy and government-controlled power distribution companies. "I encourage it. If they are upset, it needs to be sorted out," he says. Through the panchayats he sends out well-directed political messages.

The Scheduled Caste Panchayat held on April 6 was used as a platform to announce sops before the Ambedkar Jayanti celebrations on April 14 at the Dalit icon's birthplace in Mhow. He announced measures like easing the process of issuance of caste certificates, free tuition and boarding for Dalit students taking civil service exams and generous scholarships to those in national-level educational institutions like IITS and IIMS. The Mukhyamantri



Kanyadan Yojana covers the marriage costs of girls hailing from poor families.

Chauhan has had an opportunity to chart his political course unhindered largely on account of a feeble opposition. The Congress, having given BJP the jitters with its state-wide mass protests against Professor Sabharwal's death in Ujjain at the hands of Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad activists last year, has frittered away its advantage, largely due to the public rivalry between ex-chief minister Digvijay Singh and party's Guna MP Jyotiraditya Scindia. Known Digvijay supporters like former ministers Bala Bachchan and Vijaylaxmi Sadho lobbied for state party chief Subhash Yadav to be fielded from Khargone for Lok Sabha by-polls so that he could be

shunted out of the way. Also, none of the senior Congress leaders, like Union HRD Minister Arjun Singh, Commerce and Industry Minister Kamal Nath or Minister of State for Personnel and Parliamentary Affairs Suresh Pachouri, is interested in reviving the party's fortunes in the state. Bharati's Bharatiya Janashakti hasn't been able to strike a chord. She failed to secure even her home turf of Bada Malehra.

Despite the strident efforts as a part of Mission 2008, all is not hunky-dory in the state BJP, too. Resentment has been brewing at the grassroots level. For almost a year now, district-level party functionaries have used every available party forum to air their grievances of being ignored by ministers and lack of say in governance. "The problem is that most of us have been groomed in street politics of protest in opposition. It is hard for us to sit home without an aggressive political agenda," says state Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha chief and key Chauhan aide Vishwas Sarang. Working on a formula by BJP General Secretary Ananth Kumar the party is holding Vikas Shivirs to highlight the Government's achievements on development front in all the 230 assembly constituencies and plans to organise Vikas Yatras to cover rural areas in all the districts before making a clarion call for the polls through Jan Ashirvad rallies at divisional headquarters, which top party leaders will attend.

Chauhan has also done his bit to assuage the ruffled feathers by effecting a Cabinet expansion on August 25. He inducted known Bharati loyalists like Laxman Singh Gaur, Karan Singh Verma and Gaurishankar Shejwar to send out a message to all the leaders under her sway that he was willing to take them on board. Chauhan has displayed growing political maturity and leadership traits that have served the party well so far.

However, some recent episodes like corruption charges against wife Sadhna Singh have also exposed his political frailties. As he prepares to lead BJP into polls, Chauhan would do well to hone his political instincts and put into place a political management structure to sidestep the minefield that erupts around a chief minister during election time. ■